NRR-Guarantee: Bounded Commit/Defer Guarantee Surfaces and Explicit Downstream Boundaries

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Abstract

This manuscript sets the current downstream `Guarantee` surface for the Non-Resolution Reasoning (NRR) program. Its purpose is to close the next paper as a bounded claim layer rather than as a broad universality paper. Under explicit provider, family, horizon, and observability conditions, the current manuscript integrates two supported claim surfaces and two explicit boundary surfaces: frozen early ambiguity-turn resolution, downstream acceptance under the inherited mainline comparison contract, repaired first-step side-topic/ quarantine work-start, and later-horizon relation-preservation failure reporting. On the current tested-provider surface, the early ambiguity-turn `appropriate` read moves from `0 / 24` to `24 / 24` on both providers, the repaired downstream-acceptance boundary supports bounded `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent` improvement under matched `baseline vs Energy policy` conditions (both provider slices move from `0 / 24` to `24 / 24`, while Gemini still retains visible first-followthrough residuals), the auxiliary repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read remains mixed (`Anthropic = inconclusive`, `Gemini = support`; Anthropic `Baseline` remains stronger than Anthropic `NRR` on `appropriate`), and the repaired first-step side-topic surface reaches `12 / 12` on both providers. The result is a narrow downstream paper surface: two supported guarantee surfaces plus explicit downstream and later-horizon boundaries. Across those surfaces, the honest read is therefore non-uniform: the downstream-acceptance boundary remains provider-sensitive beyond its shared burden-removal gain, and the later-horizon material remains boundary-only rather than an additional supported guarantee.

1 Introduction

NRR is not an anti-LLM framework. NRR does not replace standard LLM use. NRR optimizes when to commit and when to defer, under explicit conditions.

Related work in mixed-initiative and task-oriented dialogue has long examined adaptive initiative control and goal-oriented interaction management [8, 10], while clarification-focused lines study how a system should ask follow-up questions when a user's request remains ambiguous or underspecified [9, 11, 12]. Grounding-oriented work further emphasizes that dialogue systems must recover collaboratively when interpretation is not yet fixed [13, 14]. More recent LLM-centered work has also revisited clarification under query ambiguity and abstention or withholding under uncertainty [15, 16, 17].

Within the NRR series, `Core` and `Phi` fixed the upstream position-dependent identity and state-mapping surfaces [1, 2]. `IME`, `Transfer`, and `Coupled` then constrained the interface, transfer, and dependency surfaces [3, 4, 5]. Integrated `paper7` fixed the manuscript-facing delayed-commitment comparison and boundary-honesty surface, and `Energy` fixed the current calibration/control handoff that the present manuscript now inherits as its direct upstream spine [6, 7].

The present manuscript keeps a *Guarantee-centered* ownership split, but only in that narrower sense: `Policy`, `Dynamics`, and `Policy-Verification` remain manuscript-facing supporting layers for the `Guarantee` line rather than independent completion targets or a serial upstream chain. Accordingly, the purpose of this manuscript is to close a bounded downstream paper that absorbs those layers as constrained inputs while keeping the manuscript-facing spine fixed at `paper7 -> Energy -> Guarantee`.

The Core-to-Guarantee program goal itself is not being rewritten here. What the series must establish from `Core` through `Guarantee` remains the same: a framework grounded in position-dependent identity as a first principle, closed as an engineering program of conditional utility through implementation, quality measurement, operational control, and verification. The current *non-evaluative principle* read reorganizes that same program; it does not replace the top-level goal. In this manuscript, the practical use of that read is to tighten closure discipline around a narrow notion of 'evaluation', namely full branchwise comparative evaluation during retention.

The present version is intentionally narrow. It states the currently supported bounded claim surface without promoting any unverified provider-universal, family-universal, or long-horizon statement.

Series Consistency Statement: Unsupported interpretations are never injected at a fixed evidence state, hypothesis-set expansion is evidence-gated, and unobserved possibilities remain explicitly unresolved. In this paper, the evidence-source clause is restricted to the frozen downstream support layers and the directly imported observability surfaces named for the current `Guarantee` manuscript line.

Series Extensibility Statement: NRR is a derivation-and-evaluation framework, not a closed recipe. The currently evaluated policy/operator set is treated as an evaluated set under tested conditions, not as an exhaustive set. The aim of the present manuscript is not to imply that the current runs exhaust the guarantee question, but to fix a reusable test surface: bounded supported claims, explicit boundary surfaces, explicit comparison rules, provider-sliced reporting, and visible failure boundaries that later readers can rerun, challenge, and extend under new providers, new families, and longer horizons.

2 Contributions

Under the currently fixed provider, family, horizon, and observability bounds, this manuscript makes four bounded contributions:

1. it fixes `Guarantee` as the downstream claim-owning paper under the current downstream ownership split, with the manuscript-facing spine read as `paper7 -> Energy -> Guarantee`;
2. it consolidates two already supported claim units together with one downstream-acceptance boundary and one later-horizon failure boundary into one manuscript surface with explicit supported behavior, failure boundary, and unsupported extension for each surface;
3. it imports policy and dynamics vocabulary only at the level needed to make those supported claims and boundary surfaces interpretable without widening them into theorem-level claims;
4. it reports later-horizon degradation as an explicit boundary on the supported surfaces rather than as an additional supported guarantee.

3 Program Position And Scope

This paper sits at the end of the current manuscript-facing downstream spine:

```
paper7 -> Energy -> Guarantee
```

The role split is fixed. Integrated `paper7` supplies the comparison-and-boundary-honesty upstream surface. `Energy` supplies the calibration/control handoff and the current imported evidence surface. `Policy` supplies the minimal state/action specification. `Dynamics` supplies the hold/degrade/break vocabulary over later checkpoints. `Policy-Verification` supplies the prospective matched- condition validation surface. `Guarantee` then owns the bounded claim itself under explicit conditions.

This means the manuscript has a double obligation. It must absorb the already fixed supporting layers without reopening their ownership boundaries, and it must state only those guarantee-shaped claims that remain supportable after explicit restriction of provider, family, horizon, observability, and failure boundary.

It also fixes the role of the current organizing read. The *non-evaluative principle* is used here as a way to reorganize what counts as satisfactory closure across the series, not as a theorem-level claim that supersedes the Core-to-Guarantee objective itself. In that narrower sense, `Guarantee` is the downstream line where the series must show that the program can be closed under explicit conditions without inflating its closure standard into unrestricted runtime branchwise comparison.

4 Supporting-Layer Inputs

4.1 Policy Input

The current policy layer fixes the downstream state vocabulary (`active_objective`, `suspended_objective`, `accepted_direction`, `unresolved_relation`, `quarantine`, `local_relation_block`) together with the minimal commit/defer action set. The `Guarantee` line inherits this vocabulary as its operating language and does not redesign it locally.

That vocabulary is not ornamental. The early ambiguity-turn surface is the cleanest current instance of `defer_with_resolution`: no content work should begin before a direction is accepted, and no unilateral priority choice should be made on the user's behalf. The downstream acceptance surface is

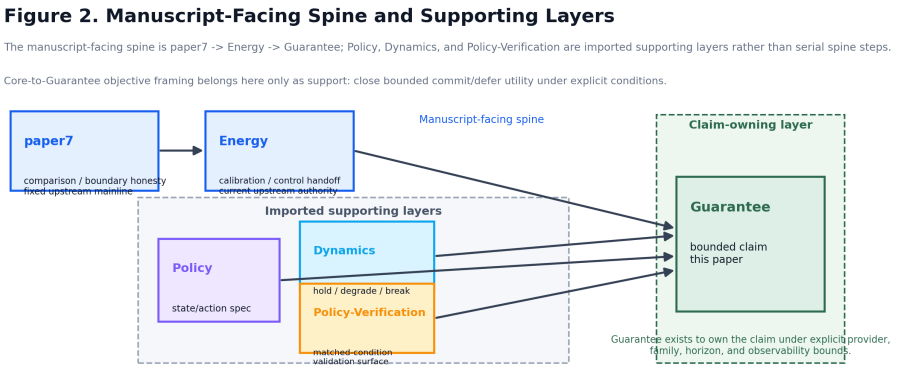

Figure 1: Current manuscript-facing spine and downstream ownership split. Integrated `paper7` and `Energy` remain the manuscript-facing upstream spine, while `Policy`, `Dynamics`, and `Policy-Verification` are imported supporting layers rather than serial spine steps. `Guarantee` remains the current claim-owning paper surface.

the current instance of `commit_to_accepted_direction` in which the honest carry-forward read is bounded support for `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent` under the mainline comparison contract, with Gemini residuals still visible beyond that shared gain rather than broad downstream closure. The repaired first-step side-topic surface is the clearest first-step instance of `accepted_direction` becoming `active_objective` while the prior line is held as `suspended_objective` under `quarantine`. The later-horizon boundary then marks the point where `unresolved_relation` handling weakens and `local_relation_block` is no longer treated conservatively. For the current downstream line, preserving an unresolved relation should also be read in a narrower but more practical sense than mere recommendation avoidance. Once a branch has already been accepted, failure can still occur if the next assistant move silently compresses still-live user-side constraint or satisfaction structure into one asserted local reading. The manuscript does not expand that point into a general hidden-needs thesis. It uses it only to mark a bounded downstream failure mode: advancing as though the user's governing criterion were already fixed when the visible interaction state does not yet support that fixation.

4.2 Dynamics Input

The current dynamics layer contributes mechanism vocabulary only. Its role is to name where the inherited policy state holds, weakens, or breaks across later checkpoints. In the current branch, the key motifs are *Stable Resolution*, *Clean Quarantine Hold*, *Useful Continuation Hold*, *Relation-Preservation Hold*, *Premature Relation Collapse*, *Repeated-Starter Attractor*, *Generic Stall*, and *Quarantine Leak*.

Using that vocabulary makes the manuscript read as one bounded progression rather than as three disconnected pilot wins. The ambiguity-turn result is the clearest instance of *Stable Resolution*. The repaired first-step side-topic result is the clearest instance of *Clean Quarantine Hold*. The downstream acceptance result remains narrower: under the manuscript's inherited `baseline vs Energy policy` comparison, the shared supported behavior is bounded removal of `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`, but Gemini still retains first-followthrough residuals, and the auxiliary repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read remains mixed, with Anthropic `Baseline` still stronger than Anthropic `NRR` on `appropriate`. That surface should not yet be collapsed into uniform *Useful Continuation Hold*. The later-horizon boundary is best read as weakening *Relation-Preservation Hold* before *Premature Relation Collapse* appears, with more local residual forms such as *Generic Stall* or *Repeated-Starter Attractor* where the template/provider slice warrants them.

4.3 Policy-Verification Input

The current policy-verification layer fixes the protocol rules that any prospective `baseline vs Energy policy` comparison must satisfy before guarantee text is allowed. This includes matched-condition comparison, pre-frozen reporting surfaces, narrow family selection, explicit horizon bands, and main-text reporting of both gains and failure boundaries.

5 Claim Unit And Boundary Discipline

Any later supported claim or explicit boundary surface in this paper must fill a single bounded reporting surface with the following fields:

1. provider scope
2. family scope

3. horizon scope
4. observability scope
5. comparison scope
6. supported behavior
7. explicit failure boundary
8. unsupported extension

No guarantee statement is valid if any field is omitted. This paper therefore inherits the current schema rule that the claim surface must be chosen before outcome inspection and must remain narrow enough to prevent provider-universal, family-universal, or long-horizon overreach.

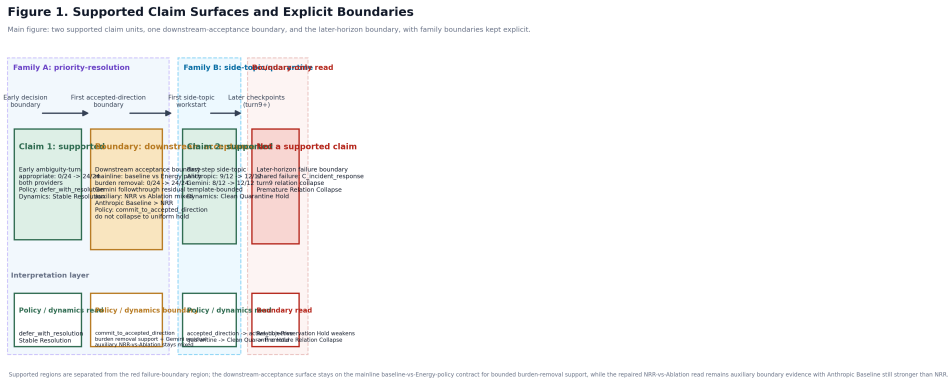

Figure 2: Supported claim progression and explicit boundary surfaces. Claim 1 and the downstream-acceptance boundary occupy different horizon points within the same `priority-resolution` family, while Claim 2 belongs to the separate first-step side-topic/quarantine family. The later-horizon region is shown as a boundary-only read rather than as an additional supported claim.

5.1 First Supported Claim Unit

The first explicit supported claim unit in the current manuscript is:

- provider scope: the tested provider pair only (`claude-sonnet-4-6` and `gemini-2.0-flash`)

- family scope: the frozen `priority-resolution` ambiguity-turn family only
- horizon scope: the early decision boundary only
- observability scope: `resolution_attempt_present`, `unilateral_commit_absent`, and `appropriate`
- comparison scope: matched baseline vs Energy-policy under the frozen early ambiguity-turn pilot conditions
- supported behavior: non-unilateral priority resolution
- explicit failure boundary: no downstream acceptance, side-topic/quarantine, or later-horizon closure is established by this fill
- unsupported extension: no provider-universal, long-horizon, or broad downstream-quality claim is authorized

In manuscript form, the bounded claim is:

> Under the tested provider pair, for the frozen `priority-resolution` ambiguity-turn family, at the early decision boundary, and on the directly scored fields `resolution_attempt_present`, `unilateral_commit_absent`, and `appropriate`, the Energy-policy arm is supported relative to matched baseline only for non-unilateral priority resolution. This support excludes downstream acceptance, side-topic/quarantine, and later-horizon behavior, and it does not extend to provider-universal or broad downstream-quality claims.

5.2 Downstream-Acceptance Boundary Surface

The current downstream-acceptance boundary surface in the manuscript is:

- provider scope: the tested provider pair only (`claude-sonnet-4-6` and `gemini-2.0-flash`)
- family scope: the downstream-acceptance family only
- horizon scope: the first accepted-direction downstream boundary only
- observability scope: `accepted_direction_followthrough_present`, `rejected_direction_intrusion_absent`, `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`, and `appropriate`

- comparison scope: matched baseline vs Energy-policy under the frozen downstream-boundary pilot conditions, with reviewed `NRR vs Ablation` retained only as an auxiliary repaired boundary comparator
- supported behavior: bounded support for removal of preacceptance rework burden under the first accepted-direction downstream boundary
- explicit failure boundary: the surface does not close as pair-wide downstream quality, provider-universal continuation support, explicit quarantine closure, or later-horizon continuation stability; Gemini still retains first-followthrough residuals, and the auxiliary repaired read remains mixed
- unsupported extension: no pair-wide downstream-acceptance guarantee, explicit quarantine closure, or later-horizon stability claim is authorized, and no manuscript claim that the auxiliary repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read replaces the paper-level comparison contract

In manuscript form, the bounded boundary read is:

> Under the tested provider pair, for the downstream-acceptance family, at the first accepted-direction downstream boundary, and on the directly scored fields `accepted_direction_followthrough_present`, `rejected_direction_intrusion_absent`, `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`, and `appropriate`, the matched `baseline vs Energy policy` surface supports only bounded removal of preacceptance rework burden rather than pair-wide downstream-quality closure: both provider slices reach `24 / 24` on `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`, but Gemini still retains partial first-followthrough residuals on part of the tested surface. The reviewed `NRR vs Ablation` read remains auxiliary boundary evidence only: Gemini reaches support there, Anthropic remains inconclusive, and the Anthropic-side auxiliary comparison keeps `Baseline` stronger than `NRR` on `appropriate`. This surface is therefore carried forward only as a bounded downstream-boundary result, not as a pair-wide downstream guarantee, explicit quarantine closure, or later-horizon stability claim.

5.3 Second Supported Claim Unit

The second explicit supported claim unit in the current manuscript is:

- provider scope: the tested provider pair only (`claude-sonnet-4-6` and `gemini-2.0-flash`)
- family scope: the repaired first-step side-topic / quarantine family only
- horizon scope: the first accepted side-topic workstart checkpoint only
- observability scope: `chosen_side_direction_workstart_present`, `suspended_main_reference` `main_direction_intrusion_absent`, and `appropriate`
- comparison scope: matched baseline vs revised Energy-policy under the repaired first-step side-topic / quarantine pilot conditions
- supported behavior: clean first-step side-topic workstart under explicit side-first acceptance
- explicit failure boundary: the gain is incremental rather than a rescue from total baseline failure, and the main lift over baseline is concentrated in `C_incident_response`
- unsupported extension: no provider-universal side-topic commitment, uniform template lift, or later- horizon side-topic stability claim is authorized

In manuscript form, the bounded claim is:

> Under the tested provider pair, for the repaired first-step side-topic / quarantine family, at the first accepted side-topic workstart checkpoint, and on the directly scored fields `chosen_side_direction_workstart_present`, `suspended_main_reference_absent`, `main_direction_intrusion_absent`, and `appropriate`, the revised Energy-policy arm is supported relative to matched baseline only for clean first-step side-topic workstart under explicit side-first acceptance. This support excludes provider-universal side-topic commitment, uniform template lift, and later-horizon side-topic stability, and it remains bounded by the fact that the main incremental lift over baseline is concentrated in `C_incident_response`.

6 Evidence Import Surface

The manuscript's evidence surface is split across three repo-local locations.

First, `supporting_layer_sources/current/` carries the fixed support-layer texts that this manuscript imports without reopening:

- Historical program design provenance: `energy_to_guarantee_program_design_brief_v1_2026`
- Policy: `policy_minimal_spec_current_v1_2026-03-18.md`
- Dynamics: `energy_dynamics_mechanism_skeleton_candidate_v2_2026-03-17.md` and `non_evaluative_principle_dynamics_closure_note_v1_2026-03-19.md`
- Policy-Verification: `policy_verification_pilot_protocol_current_v1_2026-03-18.md`
- Guarantee schema: `energy_guarantee_claim_schema_candidate_v2_2026-03-17.md`
- Historical handoff provenance: `energy_to_policy_handoff_memo_v1_2026-03-18.md`

Second, `results/analysis/` carries the manuscript-facing claim-evidence notes that fix the current bounded reads and current spine interpretation:

- `guarantee_upstream_spine_import_note_v1_2026-03-30.md`
- `guarantee_first_claim_unit_fill_v3_2026-03-30.md`
- `guarantee_phase2_downstream_acceptance_closure_import_note_v5_2026-03-30.md`
- `guarantee_downstream_acceptance_boundary_surface_v1_2026-03-30.md`
- `guarantee_third_claim_unit_fill_v2_2026-03-20.md`
- `guarantee_later_horizon_failure_boundary_v2_2026-03-20.md`
- `guarantee_policy_dynamics_manuscript_integration_v2_2026-03-20.md`
- `guarantee_behavior_first_manipulation_check_import_note_v2_2026-03-30.md`
- `guarantee_supporting_layer_evidence_map_v7_2026-03-30.md`

Third, `results/reviewed_phase2_downstream_acceptance_readout_v8/` carries the imported reviewed auxiliary repaired surface for the downstream-acceptance boundary:

- `guarantee_phase2_priority_resolution_downstream_acceptance_provider_read_table_v`
- `guarantee_phase2_priority_resolution_downstream_acceptance_nrr_vs_ablation_compa`
- `guarantee_phase2_priority_resolution_downstream_acceptance_per_protocol_supplem`
- `non_evaluative_principle_guarantee_phase2_downstream_acceptance_readout_completi`

This split is deliberate. The support bundle carries fixed upstream dependency texts and historical provenance; it is not by itself the manuscript-facing proof surface for every later bounded surface. In particular, the older downstream- acceptance memo preserved in `supporting_layer_sources/current/` remains a pre-repair historical read. The current downstream-acceptance boundary surface is instead anchored by the repo-local closure import note, the repo-local boundary-surface note, the directly shipped baseline-vs-Energy comparison memo with its four run-annotation CSVs, and the imported reviewed auxiliary repaired surface listed above.

6.1 First Evidence Import

The strongest current entry point for the `Guarantee` line is the frozen early ambiguity-turn pilot. Under matched baseline vs Energy-policy conditions, both tested provider slices moved from `0 / 24` to `24 / 24` on the pilot's `appropriate` field, while baseline failure modes remained visible as either ambiguity-preserving but unresolved responses or unilateral/content-before-resolution behavior. The externally cross-checked carry-forward read is therefore that the Energy-policy surface supports non-unilateral priority resolution at the early decision boundary on the tested provider pair. This is a bounded early-control claim only; it does not by itself establish downstream followthrough, quarantine behavior, later-horizon stability, or provider-universal validity.

6.2 Second Evidence Import

The downstream-acceptance boundary is the current second `Guarantee` entry point. The inherited paper-level comparison contract stays on matched `baseline vs Energy policy` conditions, where both tested provider slices move from `0 / 24` to `24 / 24` on `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`. That shared gain is the current supported downstream-boundary behavior. The residual remains visible in the same mainline surface: Gemini still shows partial first accepted-direction followthrough on part of the tested rows, so the claim does not close as pair-wide downstream-quality support. The imported reviewed readout then keeps a narrower auxiliary repaired comparison visible directly inside this repository: on reviewed `NRR vs Ablation`, Gemini reaches support, Anthropic remains inconclusive, and the same reviewed memo keeps Anthropic `Baseline` stronger than Anthropic `NRR` on `appropriate`. The truthful carry-forward read is therefore bounded support for preacceptance burden removal under the mainline comparison, with

the repaired `NRR vs Ablation` surface used only as auxiliary boundary evidence. This surface does not yet license pair-wide downstream guarantee language, explicit quarantine closure, later-horizon stability claims, or any claim that the auxiliary repaired read replaces the paper-level comparison contract.

6.3 Third Evidence Import

The third supportable `Guarantee` entry point is the repaired first-step side-topic / quarantine pilot. Under matched baseline vs revised Energy-policy conditions, the revised arm reached `appropriate = 12 / 12` in both provider slices, but the honest read is incremental rather than global: baseline was already fairly strong on `A_trip_planning` and `B_hiring_packet`, and the main lift over baseline concentrated in `C_incident_response` (`1 / 4 -> 4 / 4` on Anthropic and `0 / 4 -> 4 / 4` on Gemini). The carry-forward read is therefore a bounded first-step side-topic workstart claim under explicit side-first acceptance, not a universal side-topic/quarantine or later-horizon stability claim.

Behavior-First Manipulation Check A separate provider-pair rerun on the repaired behavior-first surface does not enter this paper as a supported `Guarantee` claim unit or as a boundary surface. Its narrower manuscript role is to show that, on the tested provider pair, repaired opening-comparison insertion produces a readable change in first-move behavior: implementation responses mostly remained in direct relation work, whereas ablation responses mostly opened with comparison-heavy framing. This result is therefore carried here only as bounded behavioral-separation evidence. It does not establish a clean two-stage realization: the ablation arm still most often opens with comparison framing and then continues with a follow-up question rather than separating those moves cleanly, Anthropic `D2` remains a `1 / 10` collapse row, and the rerun does not establish pair-level continuation-quality superiority. Its role in this manuscript is therefore a secondary bounded note inside the evidence-import discussion rather than a main claim unit or boundary surface.

6.4 Policy/Dynamics Interpretation Layer

Taken together, these supported and boundary surfaces define a bounded progression rather than a universal recipe. At the earliest boundary, the

supported behavior is `defer_with_resolution` and the corresponding dynamics motif is *Stable Resolution*. At the downstream acceptance boundary, the supported behavior is bounded burden removal under matched `baseline vs Energy policy` conditions, but Gemini still retains first-followthrough residuals and the auxiliary repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read remains mixed, so this surface cannot yet be read as pair-wide *Useful Continuation Hold*. At the repaired first-step side-topic boundary, the supported behavior is a clean transition from `accepted_direction` into `active_objective` with `suspended_objective` still held in quarantine, which corresponds to *Clean Quarantine Hold*. The later-horizon limit then becomes easier to state precisely: the first broad break is not simple suspended-main reactivation but weakening *Relation-Preservation Hold* until *Premature Relation Collapse* appears.

7 Later-Horizon Failure Boundary

Later-horizon material does not enter this manuscript as a supported guarantee claim. The current measured horizon family is reported only to mark where the supported first-step side-topic surface stops being safe to extend. The limited fact that the first side-topic switch can survive into the next checkpoint, and that suspended-main quarantine can still be visible there, is included only to locate the onset of failure. Later degradation remains real, template-dependent, and not uniformly distributed across providers.

The clearest shared failure surface is `C_incident_response` at `turn9`, where both providers tend to collapse the still unresolved relation by prematurely committing an ordering between `impact` and `root cause`. The correct read is therefore that later-horizon instability emerges through weakening relation preservation before suspended-main quarantine itself breaks. This later-horizon material is a boundary on the current supported surfaces, not an additional supported `Guarantee` claim.

8 Reproducibility And Repository Surface

The tracked repository surface for this manuscript is intentionally narrow and repo-local:

- a current TeX source
- a current PDF snapshot

- the current figure assets used by that TeX source
- a working drafting outline
- a supporting-layer evidence map
- bounded claim and boundary drafting memos
- an imported reviewed downstream-acceptance readout surface for the current downstream boundary
- a secondary behavior-first manipulation-check note
- a later-horizon failure-boundary memo
- a policy/dynamics manuscript-integration memo
- a bundled supporting-layer source surface
- stable build and verification wrappers

The repository therefore exposes both the manuscript-facing claim surface and the specific imported source layers used to justify it. Checksum verification executes on the tracked current artifact set, and the documented build wrapper produces a current PDF in this environment through a source-rendered fallback when cached TeX resources are incomplete. Full typeset reproduction therefore remains environment-dependent here, but the tracked repository surface is organized so the bounded claim surface, its imported reviewed downstream- boundary readout, and its support sources can be inspected without workspace- only links. Stripped comparison bundles are not the same thing as this tracked repository surface.

9 Discussion

The non-evaluative principle should enter this line as bounded engineering discipline rather than theorem inflation. In the current read, the practical issue is not simply whether unresolved content exists, but whether later interaction forces premature relation collapse while the interaction is still in a retained state. The `Guarantee` paper is the correct place to express that read as a bounded downstream claim surface. In that sense, the manuscript is adjacent to prior mixed-initiative, clarification, and grounding work, but its objective is different: it does not primarily propose a better question-asking heuristic or a general dialogue-success policy. Instead, it asks which

bounded commit/defer claims remain supportable under explicit provider, family, horizon, and observability restrictions [8, 9, 11, 14, 15, 16, 17].

That downstream read should not be reduced to a simple rule of "never recommend one next move." A response may advance with a provisional recommendation and still preserve the user's live context if the governing constraint structure remains visible or explicitly marked as contingent. The harder failure is premature interpretation fixation: proceeding as if one local reading of the user's still-live objective, satisfaction condition, or constraint ordering had already been settled. Framed that way, unresolved-relation preservation is not mere hesitation. It is bounded context retention under a visible interaction state.

The current manuscript line also remains deliberately narrow. It is based on two tested provider slices, three bounded downstream families, and one later- horizon boundary read rather than on a broad cross-provider or long-horizon guarantee. Those limits are not defects to be hidden: they are part of the bounded-claim discipline that keeps the manuscript from overstating what the current evidence surface can support.

This staging matters for how the current line should be read. The manuscript is not claiming a monotone march from early control support to pair-wide downstream success. The truthful sequence is narrower: the early ambiguity-turn surface is clean on the tested provider pair, while the repaired downstream- acceptance boundary supports only bounded preacceptance-burden removal under matched `baseline vs Energy policy` conditions, while Gemini still retains partial first-followthrough residuals and the auxiliary repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read remains mixed, with Anthropic still `inconclusive`, Gemini reaching `support`, and Anthropic `Baseline` remaining stronger than Anthropic `NRR` on `appropriate`. That asymmetry is not noise to be hidden or a reason to pretend the paper-level mainline comparison has already propagated forward into pair-wide downstream quality. It is the current bounded result.

The repaired behavior-first rerun sharpens that boundedness rather than relaxing it. Its correct manuscript role is a secondary manipulation-check note inside the evidence-import discussion: it shows that opening-comparison insertion changes how the next move is framed on the tested provider pair. But that empirical separation should not be overread as a broader downstream-quality result. The manipulated form remains compressed, one clear collapse row remains visible, and the current evidence still falls short of pair-level continuation-quality superiority. Keeping that limitation adjacent to the reported rerun result is part of the same bounded-claim discipline rather than an afterthought.

The present line should also be read as a reusable test surface rather than as the last word on guarantee behavior. What is fixed here is not an exhaustive operator set or a closed theorem, but a bounded way to keep later work honest: explicit supported claims, explicit boundary surfaces, explicit comparison surfaces, provider-sliced reporting, and visible failure boundaries. That structure is meant to make follow-on work easier. Later readers should be able to rerun these guarantee questions under new providers, new downstream families, new operator variants, and longer horizons without having to guess which comparison contract or boundary rule the current manuscript relied on.

10 Conclusion

This version establishes a bounded manuscript surface for `Guarantee`. It fixes the downstream ownership split, consolidates two supported claim units for the early ambiguity-turn surface and the repaired first-step side-topic/quarantine surface, carries the downstream-acceptance boundary forward as bounded support for `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent` on the mainline `baseline vs Energy policy` comparison while keeping the repaired `NRR vs Ablation` read as an auxiliary comparator, and keeps the later-horizon limit explicit as failure-boundary reporting rather than as a further supported claim. It also ties those supported and unsupported regions directly to the inherited policy vocabulary and dynamics motifs without promoting the line into provider-universal, family-universal, or theorem-level language. In practical terms, the current `Guarantee` line closes this pass around a staged bounded result: early control support does not automatically extend into pair-wide downstream acceptance, the repaired downstream boundary remains limited to burden removal rather than pair-wide downstream quality, and the Anthropic-side auxiliary comparison keeps `Baseline` stronger than `NRR` on `appropriate`. What remains outside the present claim surface is broader provider coverage, broader downstream family coverage, and later-horizon closure. The manuscript therefore aims to do one more thing than simply close the current bounded read: it fixes a reusable test surface that later readers can rerun, challenge, and extend under new conditions rather than treating the present line as exhaustive.

References

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Unit	Scope	Supported behavior	Boundary kept explicit
Early ambiguity-turn	Tested provider pair, frozen priority-resolution family, early decision boundary	Non-unilateral priority resolution	No downstream acceptance, side-topic/quarantine, or later-horizon extension
Downstream acceptance boundary	Tested provider pair, downstream-acceptance family, first accepted-direction boundary	Bounded support for preacceptance burden removal under matched baseline vs Energy-policy conditions	Keep Gemini residuals and the auxiliary repaired read explicit; do not collapse into pair-wide or provider-universal downstream-guarantee language
First-step side-topic/quarantine	Tested provider pair, repaired side-topic family, first accepted side-topic workstart checkpoint	Clean first-step side-topic workstart under explicit side-first acceptance	Incremental lift remains template-bounded and does not authorize later-horizon stability
Later-horizon boundary	Measured later checkpoints only	No additional supported guarantee claim	Failure appears as weakening relation preservation and premature relation collapse, especially on `C_incident_response` at `turn9`

Table 1: Current supported and boundary surfaces in `Guarantee`.

Surface	**Provider scope**	**Horizon scope**	**Direct observability scope**
Early ambiguity-turn	Tested provider pair (`claude-sonnet-4-6`, `gemini-2.0-flash`)	Early decision boundary	`resolution_attempt_present`, `unilateral_commit_absent`, `appropriate`
Downstream acceptance boundary	Tested provider pair (`claude-sonnet-4-6`, `gemini-2.0-flash`)	First accepted-direction downstream boundary	`accepted_direction_followthrough_present`, `rejected_direction_intrusion_absent`, `preacceptance_rework_burden_absent`, `appropriate`
First-step side-topic / quarantine	Tested provider pair (`claude-sonnet-4-6`, `gemini-2.0-flash`)	First accepted side-topic workstart checkpoint	`chosen_side_direction_workstart_present`, `suspended_main_reference_absent`, `main_direction_intrusion_absent`, `appropriate`
Behavior-first manipulation check	Tested provider pair (`claude-sonnet-4-6`, `gemini-2.0-flash`)	First next-move framing only	opening-comparison framing separation, direct relation work retention, and the visible Anthropic `D2` collapse row
Later-horizon boundary	Tested provider pair (`claude-sonnet-4-6`, `gemini-2.0-flash`)	Measured later checkpoints, especially `turn9`	Relation-preservation failure surfaces, most clearly unresolved-relation collapse on `C_incident_response`

Table 2: Exact tested scope carried forward into the current `Guarantee` manuscript.

Surface	Primary source artifact	Direct observability fields	Current read in this paper	Boundary kept explicit
Early ambiguity-turn	`guarantee_first_claim_unit_v2_2026-03-30.md`	`resolution_unit`, `unilateral_commitment`, `appropriate`	Not implemented; commitment-resolution at the early decision boundary	No downstream acceptance, side-topic/quarantine, or later-horizon extension
Downstream acceptance boundary	`guarantee_phase2_pair_v2_2026-03-30.md`	`rejected_direction`, `preacceptance_work`, `appropriate`	Bounded follow-through present; direction-intrusion residuals remain, but `rejected_direction_intrusion_absent`, `preacceptance_work_burden_absent`, `appropriate`	Keep Current `guarantee_phase2_pair_note_v5_2026-03-30.md` decisive basis: `energy_policy_baseline_vs_energy_policy_c` (+ 4 run-annotation CSVs)
First-step side-topic / quarantine	`guarantee_third_claim_unit_v2_2026-03-20.md`	`chosen_side`, `suspended_main`, `main_direction_instruction_absent`, `appropriate`	Child v2 preserves side-topic preference under explicit side-first acceptance	Bifurcation present, but not fully bounded, with strongest gain on `C_incident_response`
Behavior-first manipulation check	`guarantee_behavior_first_manipulation_check_v2_2026-03-20.md`	`prior_comparison`, `direct_relation_work`, `visible_Anthropic_D2_collapse_row`	Supplementary bounded behavioral-separation note only	Not claim unit or pair-level continuation-quality superiority claim
Later-horizon boundary	`guarantee_later_horizon_failure_boundary_v2_2026-03-20.md`	Relation preservation failure surfaces at later checkpoints, especially	Non-additive, evidence-supported guarantee claim	Preserve later-horizon material as failure-boundary

Surface	**Anthropic-side read**	**Gemini-side read**	**Boundary implication**
Early ambiguity-turn	Clean support on the tested early surface	Clean support on the tested early surface	Safe to state only a bounded early-control claim, not broader downstream closure
Downstream acceptance boundary	Mainline burden-removal support is clean; auxiliary repaired read stays `inconclusive` and keeps `Baseline` stronger than `NRR` on `appropriate`	Mainline burden-removal support is present, but first-followthrough residuals remain visible; auxiliary repaired read reaches `support`	Keep the claim at bounded burden-removal support under the mainline contract; use the repaired read only as boundary evidence, not as a replacement comparison rule
First-step side-topic / quarantine	Lift is visible, with strongest incremental gain on `C_incident_response`	Lift is also visible, again with the main gain concentrated on `C_incident_response`	Treat the result as template-bounded improvement, not uniform side-topic stability
Later-horizon boundary	Degradation remains visible at later checkpoints	Degradation remains visible at later checkpoints	Preserve later-horizon text as boundary reporting rather than a fourth supported guarantee

Table 4: Provider-specific residual structure that keeps the current `Guarantee` claims bounded.